The city was built across the river from Kishkindha, site of the monkey-kingdom described in the Ramayana. It is a dramatic landscape of rock outcrops and gigantic boulders. The choice of location, therefore, was no coincidence as the rocky terrain partly neutralized the military advantages of Turkic cavalry. An additional advantage was that the place had easy access to iron-ore from the nearby mines of Bellary, still in active use today.

A number of visitors have left us lucid accounts of Vijayanagar, including Abdul Razzaq, envoy from the Persian court, and several Europeans such as Domingo Paes and Fernão Nunes. They tell us that the city was encircled by a series of concentric walls, perhaps as many as seven of them, that enclosed a massive area. The large gap between the first and second wall was used mostly for gardens and farming. The inner walls enclosed bazaars, homes, mansions and temples. At the core of the city was a magnificent palace-complex surrounded by strong fortifications. Despite thinking of itself consciously as a bastion of classical Hinduism, the city was very cosmopolitan with sizeable populations of Muslims, Christians and even Jews. Paes tells us that ‘the people of this city are countless in number, so much so that I do not wish to put it down for fear that it should be thought fabulous’. He goes on to say ‘This is the best provided city in the world … the streets and markets are full of laden oxen so much so that you cannot get along for them’.[12]

The remains of the city can be visited at Hampi in Karnataka, and can only be described as spectacular. In my many travels across the world, I have found only the ruins of Angkor in Cambodia to be comparable to those of Hampi in terms of sheer scale. It is too large to be explored solely on foot and the visitor will need both a car and a good guide. As described by the medieval travellers, there is still a fair amount of farming that continues within the UNESCO World Heritage site, in many cases using the old canals. We even have remnants of a system of stone aqueducts that brought water into the city. The remains of temples, palaces and bazaars make it clear that the reports about the city’s size were not exaggerations. Indeed, after decades of excavations, much of the site has still not been uncovered. One of the more remarkable remains is that of Ugra Narasingha—a gigantic